# UNIT 4: STRATEGIES FOR SUCCESS

## PART II: OBTAINING AND RETAINING WORK

### TOPIC 7: JOB RETENTION

#### Lesson 1: Positive Work Habits

**Topic OBJECTIVE:** The learner will:

- Understand and practice workplace expectations

**Topic OUTCOME:** The learner will:

- Understand the importance of performing professionally on a job-site including successfully managing employment expectations

**Topic ACTIVITIES:**

**Large Group Discussion**

Objective: Students will learn workplace expectations.
Time: 20 minutes
Materials: Handouts: **"Keep the Job"** and **"Keep that Job Self-Check Sheets,"** pens/pencils

Hand out the **"Keep the Job"** handout to students, and ask them to write and share their ideas on ways to keep a job (such as, being on time, having reliable transportation, responding well to suggestions, etc.). The **"Keep that Job Self-Check Sheet"** handout will provide them with more ideas for this lesson and for future reference.

Explain to students that when on the job, asking questions when they are unsure is a good way to clarify work expectations and responsibilities. Inform students that if they do not ask questions when they are unsure, they run the risk of making a mistake on the job.

**Writing/Reflection/Assessment/Consensus**

Objective: Students will create and share strategies for dealing with on-the-job scenarios.
Time: 20 minutes
Materials: Handouts: **"Is That A Good Reason?"** and **"Identifying Problems,"** scissors, **"Issues with Work"** sheet (cut), pens/pencils

Ask students to name some of the reasons why it is important to show up for work when scheduled. Hand out **"Is that a Good Reason?"** sheets, and have students "vote" (show of hands) on each one. If comfortable, students who wish to can volunteer their reasoning behind their vote. Remind them that though they think they might have a good reason for missing work, it is their responsibility to show up as scheduled unless there is an emergency or they have pre-arranged time off.

Cut the phrases on the **"Issues with Work Sheet"** into individual strips and put in a hat/box/etc. for students to draw out of. Hand out the **"Identifying Problems"** sheet. Have student volunteers draw and read the phrases aloud (or the instructor can read them). Ask students to write the issue in the left column of their sheets, and their own idea of a possible strategy or solution in the right hand column. If comfortable, volunteers can share their strategies and/or the class can brainstorm more ideas as well.

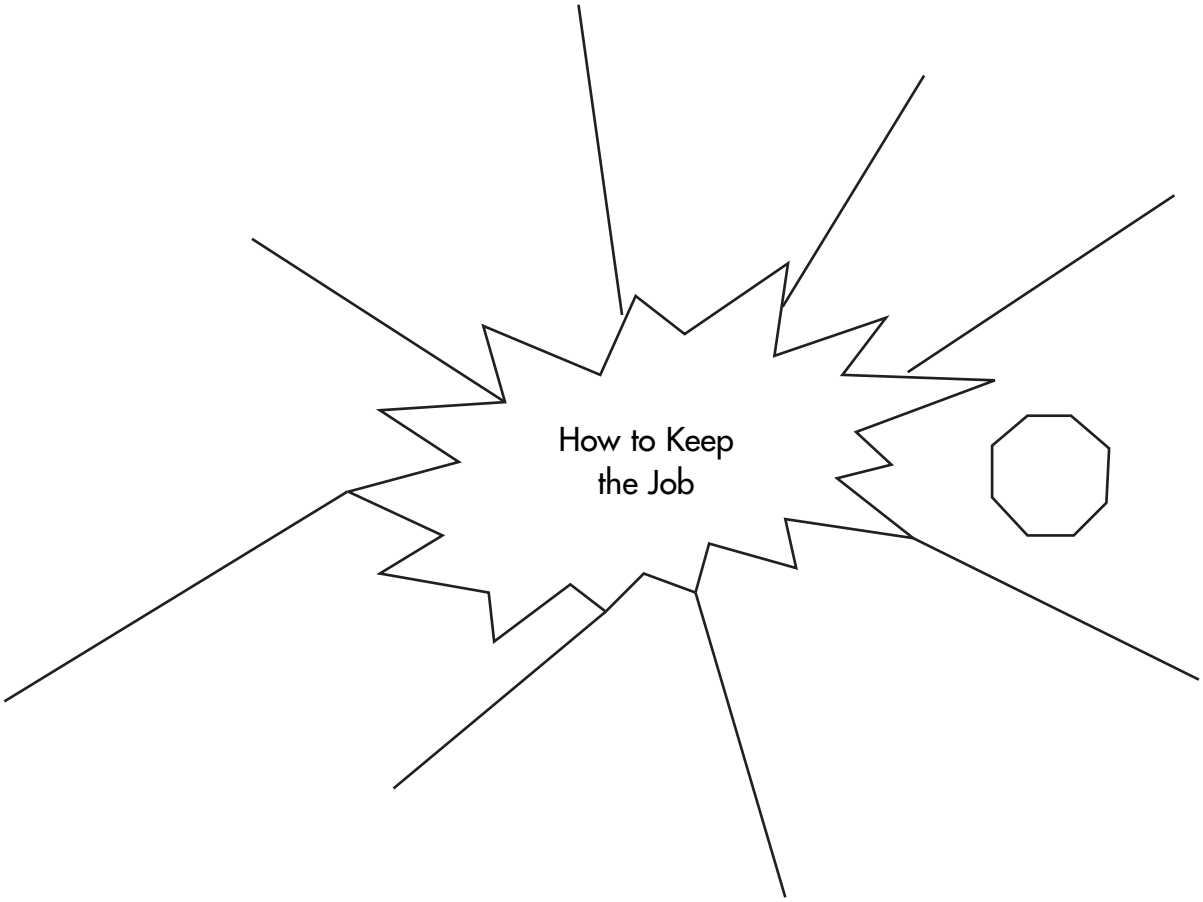
**Technical (Mass CIS)/Research**

Objective: Students will use web-based career resources to learn more about job retention and advancement strategies.
Time: 10 minutes
Materials: Computers with internet connection, index cards with students' **Mass CIS** log-in names and passwords

Have the students log on to the **Mass CIS** website **(www.masscis.intocareers.org).** Explain that this site has a wealth of information on getting and maintaining a job. Ask students to look under **"Occupations and Employment,"** on the home page, and click on **"Keep That Job"** link. Have them explore the resources available on good work habits, dealing with co-workers, looking into promotions, etc.

## Keep the Job

List ways to keep the job. Check the KEEP THE JOB SELF CHECK SHEET (worksheet 7K). Add ideas to complete your web.




Adapted from Merging Two Worlds, 2003

## Keep the Job Self Check Sheet

1. **Be on time.**
   - Use alarm clock.
   - Set alarm on your phone.
   - Plan reliable transportation.
   - Take traffic into account.
   - Prepare your clothes, food, etc. for work the night before.
   - Try to get a good amount of sleep.

2. **Follow company rules. Follow safety rules.**
   - Ask for a copy of company rules.
   - Make sure you know how/where to document hours (time-sheet, punch clock, etc.) so you get paid properly and on time!
   - Take time off only when really needed — many absences could make you lose your job.
   - If you are going to be late or are not going to make it to work, call your supervisor as soon as possible to let them know.

3. **Do your job well.**
   - Have a positive attitude.
   - Learn from others.
   - Be open to feedback from supervisor.

4. **Wear clothes appropriate for the job.**
   - Follow the same rules as for a job interview.
   - If a uniform is required, make sure it is clean and put together the proper way.

5. **Cooperate and compromise with your co-workers. Don't argue or fight.**
   - Try to see the opposing person's side.
   - Get help from a supervisor when you feel stuck, rather than making things worse.

6. **Don't use drugs or alcohol.**

7. **Get along with your supervisor.**
   - Ask questions.
   - Offer help/volunteer to take on tasks.
   - Listen and act upon suggestions.

8. **Be honest.**

9. **Keep professional and personal lives separate.**
   - Don't gossip.
   - Don't take or make personal calls.
   - Don't text.
   - Turn off your cell phone!

10. **If you aren't sure what to do or how to do it, ask your supervisor.**

Adapted from Merging Two Worlds, 2003

## Is That a Good Reason

There are good and bad reasons to be absent from work. Review the following list and decide which are adequate (ok/acceptable) reasons for missing work. Put a check next to which reasons you think would be accepted by your supervisor.

- ☐ I have a meeting with my lawyer.
- ☐ I sprained my ankle and must keep it raised.
- ☐ I ran out of gas.
- ☐ I need to get a new pair of glasses today.
- ☐ My house was robbed last night.
- ☐ I have to visit my sick friend.
- ☐ This is a religious holiday for me.
- ☐ I have a hangover.
- ☐ I have a headache and don't feel like coming in.
- ☐ My child is ill, and I must stay home with him/her.
- ☐ My car isn't working, and I don't have a ride.
- ☐ I had a car accident on the way to work.
- ☐ There's been a death in my family.
- ☐ I have to baby-sit my sister's children
- ☐ I had a fight with my boyfriend/girlfriend and I'm too angry to work.

## Identifying your work-related problems

When starting a new job, it is important to be prepared and have a great attitude.

In the space provided below, list the issues and problems that you may have at your new job. Also think of tasks you need to do before starting the job, such as arranging transportation. For each issue or problem, list a solution. For each task, list the steps you need to take to complete the task. For example, an issue could be that you do not have child care. A solution could be to look into nearby child care facilities and ask friends and family members if they can watch your children on certain days. Try to be specific when listing your solutions or steps so that it is clear what you need to do.

| Problem, issue, or task | Solution or steps to be taken |
|---|---|
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Adapted from Mass CIS www.masscis. intocareers.org

## Issues with Work

No Car. How will I get to work?

My infant daughter is sick today and doesn't have day-care.

I want time off to go to my cousin's wedding.

I can't seem to get up in the mornings to make it to work on time.

My supervisor says I need to wear a collared shirt every day, and I only have two.

My girlfriend wants me to call her when I am at work.

My supervisor asked me to run a certain machine, but I am not sure how to do it.

## Lesson 2: Communication

**Topic OBJECTIVE:** The learner will:

- Identify and understand workplace communication expectations

**Topic OUTCOME:** The learner will:

- Understand and demonstrate professional workplace communication skills including effective strategies to address potential workplace conflicts

**Topic ACTIVITIES:**

### Large Group Discussion

Objective: Students will learn about the importance of careful listening and positive non-verbal communication in the workplace.

Time: 30 minutes

Materials: Handouts: "Personal Life vs. Work Life," "Listening and Speaking Tips" and "Non-Verbal Communication," pens/pencils

General Rules for Communicating at Work

Explain to students that it is important to "treat others as you would like to be treated" in the workplace. It is also important to be respectful, polite, clear, and open to feedback from supervisors and co-workers. In addition, it is generally expected for co-workers to greet each other and to have a pleasant demeanor with each other and customers, even when they "don't feel like it." Use the handout "Personal Life vs. Work Life" to highlight how different perspectives and behaviors are required for both.

Emphasize to the class that when new on the job, asking questions is the fastest way to learn and understand their responsibilities and the workplace rules. Also, it is sometimes tough to hear critical feedback, but it is a necessary part of having a job.

Listening/Non-Verbal Communication

Ask students to identify ways to communicate without speaking (non-verbal communication). Talk about body language, attentive listening, facial expressions, etc. Reinforce that people send out messages all the time, even when they are not talking. Pass out "Listening and Speaking Tips" and "Non-Verbal Communication." Read the story about "Ruben" on the "Non-Verbal Communication" sheet, and have students share or write down their answers to the discussion questions in the spaces provided.

### Writing/Reflection/Assessment

Hand out "Tips for Managing Conflict." Have students share which, if any, of the tips have worked for them in the past, and what other strategies they may have to effectively manage conflict. Ask students to circle the tips on the handout that they will try in the future, and to write down an additional one in the space provided.

### Role-Play Activity

Objective: Students will discuss and practice strategies for managing conflict using "I messages" in the workplace.

Time: 20 minutes

Materials: Handouts: "Tips for Managing Conflict" and "Strategies for Handling Conflict: Practicing I Messages" for everyone, pens/pencils

Depending on the comfort level of the class, students may role-play the workplace scenarios from the "Strategies for Handling Conflict: Practicing I Messages." Have them practice resolving conflict using the template of the "I Messaging" handout.

As an alternative, ask students to write their answers on the sheet, and ask volunteers to share. Acknowledge that there is no perfect system or strategy for avoiding conflict in every situation, but it is good to try and come to a peaceful resolution.

# Personal Life vs. Work Life

| Personal | Work |
| --- | --- |
| • **Life should be fun.** | • **Work is work. Don't expect it to always be fun!** |
| • You should be appreciated for who you are. | • Deal with your personal feelings on your own time. Work comes FIRST! |
| • You should be liked by your pals. | • Do what you are asked/told, even if you don't want to. |
| • You should be able to trust your friends. | • You are paid to do your job. Don't expect a raise for doing the minimum. |
| • Friends should help each other with problems. | • Do your best to fit in. Don't dress too differently. |
| • If you make a mistake, you should keep it to yourself. | • Be friendly, but don't expect your co-workers to be your pals. |
| • Personal appearance is your decision. | • If you mess up, ask for help. |
| • You should be able to live by your own rules. | • Stay out of other's problems. |
| • You should be open and honest about your feelings. | • There are NO secrets at work!!! |

Adapted from www.lehigvalleycareerlink.com

## Speaking and Listening

When communicating, both the speaker and the listener are responsible for making sure a message is understood.

**Listening Tips:**

| DOs | DON'Ts |
|---|---|
| **Look at the speaker** | Rush, interrupt, or finish sentences for the speaker |
| **Pay attention** | Think about what you're going to say while the other person is speaking |
| **Ask questions** | Stop listening because you disagree with the speaker |
| **Repeat what is said in your own words** | Walk away unless you understand what has been said |

## Non-Verbal Communication

Your attitude toward your job will be judged in part by your nonverbal communication. Here are some dos and don'ts:

***DO*** *make eye contact*
***DO*** *assume a pleasant facial expression*
***DO*** *sit up straight and lean forward slightly.*

***DON'T*** *slouch*
***DON'T*** *put your feet up*
***DON'T*** *smack or crack chewing gum*
***DON'T*** *sigh loudly*
***DON'T*** *check your phone for messages or texts*

### Think About It

Ruben, a teacher's aide, was attending a staff meeting at the child-care center. The director had been speaking for fifteen minutes about the center's plan to reorganize the play areas. Ruben was interested about the plan and was eager to get to work, but he felt the director was wasting time explaining and justifying every step of the plan.

Ruben slouched lower in his seat and put one foot up on an empty chair. He examined his fingernails and began cleaning them with a nail file he had on his key chain. As the director continued talking, he looked at his watch, raised his eyebrows, and sighed loudly.

**What nonverbal signals did Ruben send?**

**How do you think the director interpreted his nonverbal signals?**

**Did Ruben's nonverbal communication really reflect how he felt about the project? Explain.**

**How might Ruben have non-verbally communicated a more positive attitude during the meeting?**

Adapted from Merging Two Worlds, 2003

## Tips for Managing Conflict

- ☐ **Be assertive not aggressive (state your case but keep your cool)**
- ☐ **Pick a good time and place for both people**
- ☐ **Don't bring up the past**
- ☐ **Get the facts**
- ☐ **Deal only with the current conflict**
- ☐ **Avoid words like "always" and "never"**
- ☐ **Try to understand your own feelings and the other person's feelings**
- ☐ **Stay calm**
- ☐ **Have a sense of humor**
- ☐ **Keep things in perspective**

Write your personal tips to yourself that remind you how to stay out of a conflict.

Adapted from Merging Two Worlds, 2003

## Strategies for Handling Conflicts — Practicing "I" Messages

Here are some work situations that might easily become conflicts. See if you can come up with an I Message for each. Be assertive, which means express how you might feel and what you think without starting a fight:

1. Your co-worker, Jason, did not show up for work. When you try to reach him, he is not home. Later you find out that he mis-read the schedule and didn't think he was supposed to work.

   I feel _____ when you _____

   I would appreciate _____

2. Jean starts a rumor about you that gets back to your boss. You have to prove it was wrong.

   When you _____ I feel _____

   I want _____

3. Your boss calls you by a nickname that you do not like.

   I feel _____ when you _____

   I would like _____

4. Your job requires you to work in teams. Sarah does not do her fair share making the rest of the team work harder to make up for her.

   When you _____ I feel _____

   I'd appreciate _____

5. Jennifer often uses the phone during work hours even though it is against business policy, and it is noisy and distracting you from your work.

   When you _____ I feel _____

   I'd appreciate _____

Adapted from Merging Two Worlds, 2003